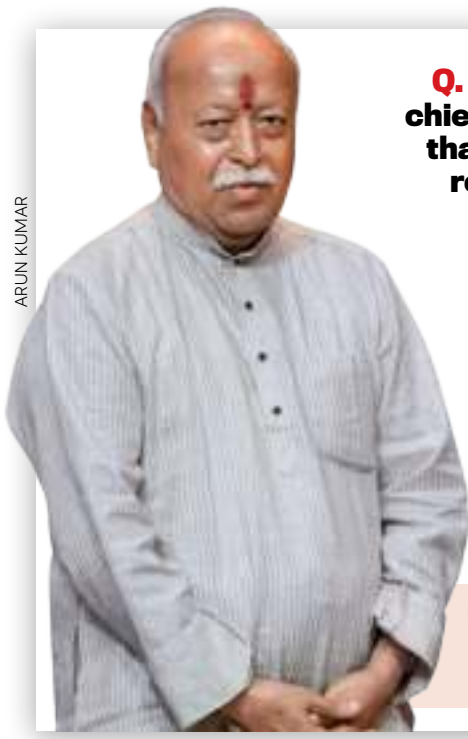


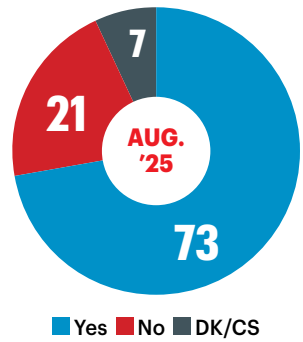
RANJAN RAHI

FROM A 24% POINT GAP IN AUG. 2024 BETWEEN MODI AND MANMOHAN SINGH'S HANDLING OF THE ECONOMY, THE DIFFERENCE THIS TIME HAS NARROWED TO A MERE 2% POINTS



ARUN KUMAR

Q. Do you agree with RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's view that public leaders should retire by the age of 75?



Nearly three-fourths of respondents concur with Bhagwat on the retirement age for public leaders

the same in the next six months.

Even worse for the Modi dispensation is the perception that its economic policies are skewed towards the rich. As many as 56 per cent believe that big business has benefited most from its economic policies to the detriment of small firms, farmers and the salaried class. This despite the NDA government running the world's largest food security programme, which benefits more than 800 million people. Over 60 per cent of respondents are cross that their economic status has remained the same or deteriorated since Modi came to power in 2014. Perhaps the most telling is the drastic reduction in the estimation of Modi's economic performance compared to that of Manmohan Singh. There is a difference of just 2 percentage points—45 per cent favouring Modi and 43 per cent Manmohan Singh—in their respective economic performance. This when just a year ago, in the August 2024 MOTN poll, Modi was miles ahead with a 22 percentage point lead over his predecessor.

A Weak Opposition

If there is so much concern and criticism over the Modi government's handling of the economy, why do voters continue to repose their faith in Modi, the BJP and their NDA allies to govern India? One major reason is that the Opposition, especially the INDIA bloc, is not yet perceived to be a potential threat to the NDA. There is a 5.8 percentage point difference in vote share between the two political alliances. The NDA is projected to win 324 Lok Sabha seats were a general election held today and INDIA, a mere 208 seats, a 26-seat drop from the 234 it actually won in the 2024 general election. Encouragingly, though, regional leaders such as Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, M.K. Stalin in Tamil Nadu and even Tejashwi Yadav in Bihar have improved their Lok Sabha standing in this MOTN poll. Which goes to prove only one thing: more than the constituents of the INDIA bloc, it is the Congress's electoral performance or lack thereof